Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION · FREE SAMPLER

Is a Finance Degree Worth It in the AI Era? The 2026 Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

8.0

AI EXPOSURE · ENTRY ANALYST / RESEARCH

where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOUR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Quick answer: An entry-level financial analyst role scores **8.0 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk — among the highest in this index. Wealth and financial advisory scores **4.6**. The 3.4-point spread is one of the widest we measure. Finance protects the person in the room with the client, and offers very little to the person preparing the materials for that room.

The short answer for parents: yes for the relationship and judgment tiers — advising people, managing risk, owning decisions. Much less so for the spreadsheet tier, which is both the most automatable work we score and the traditional way in.

Finance AI risk score by track

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to an analyst and a paramedic.

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVE	BAND
Wealth / financial advisory	3.9	4.2	**4.6**	+0.7	Low–Moderate
Risk & compliance	4.5	4.8	**5.3**	+0.8	Moderate
Investment banking (senior)	4.9	5.3	**5.7**	+0.8	Moderate
Corporate finance / FP&A	6.0	6.4	**6.8**	+0.8	Moderate–High
Entry analyst / research	6.4	7.3	**8.0**	+1.6	High

2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.

How that compares: the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. A business analyst scores **7.6**. Entry-level software development scores **8.1**. Bedside nursing scores **2.8**.

The entry analyst track moved +1.6 in three years — fourth-fastest in the index. One honest caveat on that figure appears below.

Will AI replace financial analysts?

It is doing a great deal of what junior analysts were hired to do, and almost none of what senior advisors do.

AI IS TAKING	IT CAN'T TOUCH
Financial modeling and scenario building	Sitting across from someone making the biggest financial decision of their life
Company and sector research	Judgment on risks that don't match historical patterns
Earnings analysis and comparables	Being called when markets fall
Pitch book and deck production	Regulatory accountability for advice given
Data assembly and cleaning	Persuading a client not to do something stupid
First-draft memos and commentary	Fiduciary responsibility

Major firms have begun testing whether candidates can *direct* AI through modeling and research, rather than perform it, in final-round interviews. That is a profession redesigning what a first-year is for.

Why does advisory hold up? The six factors

How wealth and financial advisory rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

FACTOR	RATING	EFFECT ON RISK
How much of this job can AI already do?	6.3	↑ moderate exposure
How hard will it be to land that first job?	4.0	↑ moderate exposure
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	2.0	↓ almost none
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	9.0	↓ strong protection
Does the law require a licensed human?	8.0	↓ strong protection
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	7.5	↓ good protection

ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

So you can see what the analysis actually looks like.

Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible? — rated 9.0 for advisors, 4.0 for analysts

Finance is almost entirely a screen-based profession. Nobody in it is protected by physical presence. So this one factor does most of the work separating a 4.6 from an 8.0, and it is worth understanding precisely what it measures.

Two things sit inside it. **Trust**: does someone need a specific human they can rely on? **Accountability**: must a human carry responsibility when it goes wrong?

A financial advisor rates 9.0 on both. Clients hand over decisions about retirement, a house, a child's education, an inheritance. When markets fall they want to speak to a person who knows their situation and can be held to the advice. Fiduciary and suitability obligations attach to a licensed human, not to a system. One firm leader's analogy is worth borrowing: robots assist in surgery every day, and patients still expect a surgeon in the room.

An entry-level analyst rates 4.0. They produce work that someone else signs off. No client knows their name. Nobody is relying on them personally, and no regulatory obligation attaches to them individually. The work is real and the accountability sits above them.

The pattern generalizes across this whole index: exposure falls as personal accountability rises. The further a role sits from someone answering for the outcome, the less protected it is — which is why the model consistently finds senior work safer than junior work in every profession that lacks a physical or licensing moat.

The uncomfortable implication for a finance graduate is that the protection cannot be acquired at the start. It has to be earned, and the roles where you traditionally earned it are the ones being compressed.

Which finance careers are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **Wealth / financial advisory — 4.6.** Trust, licensing and long-term client relationships. 2. **Risk & compliance — 5.3.** Regulatory accountability and judgment on non-pattern events. 3. **Investment banking, senior — 5.7.** Deal judgment and relationships, though heavily supported by automatable work. 4. **Corporate finance / FP&A — 6.8.** Business partnering, with substantial automatable reporting content. 5. **Entry analyst / research — 8.0.** The most automatable work in the field, and the traditional entry route.

One honest caveat about these numbers

Finance is the most cyclical profession we score, and that makes its three-year trend harder to read than any other.

Deal activity slumped sharply in 2023–24 and recovered as rates stabilized. Hiring at major banks moved with it. So some portion of the +1.6 on the analyst track is almost certainly the deal cycle rather than automation, and we cannot cleanly separate the two.

What persuades us to hold a high score is the *content* of the surviving roles rather than their count. When firms describe the first-year job as directing and checking AI output rather than building the model, the apprenticeship has changed even if headcount recovers. A graduate can get the analyst seat and still not get the training the seat used to provide.

We will be watching analyst class sizes through a full deal cycle before concluding either way, and we will say so if we were wrong.

Is a finance degree still worth it in 2026?

Yes, with the destination clearly in mind.

The safe end of finance — advisory, wealth management, risk, compliance — is protected by things that have not moved: licensing, fiduciary obligation, and clients wanting a human. Those are durable protections in our framework.

The traditional route in is the part under pressure. The two-year analyst program exists to do precisely the work AI now does, and the advisory door was never open to new graduates anyway; it is earned through years and trust.

The degree versions that hold up pair finance with real quantitative depth — the people building the models remain scarcer than the people running them — or point explicitly at licensed advisory paths.

Worth asking any program: what proportion of graduates enter analyst programs versus client-facing or risk roles, and how has that mix shifted in three years? **The shift is the market telling you where the jobs went.**

Common questions

Will AI replace financial analysts? It is displacing a large share of the work already — modeling, research, comparables and deck production are among the most automatable tasks we score. Entry analyst roles score 8.0.

Is finance a good career in 2026? At the advisory and risk end, yes. The entry tier is genuinely difficult, and the difficulty is partly automation and partly a cycle we cannot fully separate from it.

What finance jobs are safest from AI? Wealth and financial advisory at 4.6, then risk and compliance at 5.3. Both are protected by trust and licensing rather than by anything technical.

Is investment banking still worth it? Senior deal work scores 5.7 and remains valuable. The two-year analyst program that traditionally led there is the exposed part, and its content has already changed.

Is finance safer than accounting? At the top, finance advisory (4.6) beats CPA advisory (5.2). At the bottom, finance is worse — entry analyst 8.0 against bookkeeping 7.9, and accounting's licensure props its on-ramp open in a way finance's does not.

Related profiles

- **Accounting** — 7.9 transactional, 5.2 CPA advisory
- **Business and management** — 7.6 analyst, 4.9 leadership
- **Computer science** — 8.1 entry-level, 5.4 senior. Free to read in full.
- **Law** — 7.9 junior associate, 4.5 trial advocacy

- Data science & analytics — coming in this edition

What's in the full finance profile

This sampler tells you where finance stands. The full profile tells you what to do about it.

	SAMPLER	FULL PROFILE
Verdict, all track scores, 3-year trend	✓	✓
Six-factor ratings	✓	✓
Reasoning behind every factor rating	one example	✓
How durable each protection is		✓
The cyclical confound in full — and how to read the trend properly		✓
The honest downsides — hours, culture, attrition, geographic concentration		✓
What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits		✓
The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening		✓
Routes in — analyst programs, licensing paths, quantitative routes		✓
Where the degree leads later		✓
Program evaluation checklist — placement, quantitative depth, outcome data		✓
Questions to ask a program — plus red flags		✓
Sourced further reading, including the case against our score		✓
Discussion questions for parent and student		✓
A short version written directly to the student		✓
Technical scoring appendix		✓

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Each full profile includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. Spring 2027 updates of whatever you buy are included.

Read a complete profile free → We publish one profile in full, openly, so you can judge the depth before buying anything. Computer science is the one to read — it's the most surprising result in the index.

Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.